



Traveling pilgrims are shown in an illustration from the *Canterbury Tales*. This unfinished poem by Geoffrey Chaucer, 17,000 lines long, vividly illustrates the medieval world view on social, religious, and moral matters.

JAGIELLO OF LITHUANIA

(c. 1362–1434), THE LAST PAGAN

RULER in Europe, was crowned king of Poland and converted to Christianity in 1386. Marriage to **Jadwiga of Poland** united the two kingdoms, and brought Lithuania into the Catholic Church, although pagan traditions lingered on.

Timur Leng (see 1356–65) completed his **conquest of Persia** in 1386 and raided deep into the Caucasus, sacking **Tbilisi** in Georgia and capturing the Georgian king. However, when the army of the **Golden Horde** attacked his Central Asian territories, in 1387, he was forced to turn back and meet them. It took another nine years for him to destroy the threat.

Geoffrey Chaucer (c. 1340–1400) was a soldier, scholar, writer, diplomat, government official, and

CHRISTIANIZATION OF EUROPE

In Europe, the medieval period saw the vigorous advance of Christianity until it encompassed the entire region (with just a few exceptions). The spectacular success in converting Europe posed extreme challenges to the Church, as it struggled to reconcile temporal and spiritual power. Internal forces would continue to revolutionize the religion.



Member of Parliament. He was instrumental in the development of **Middle English**—a combination of Old English and French influences. His greatest work, the

Canterbury Tales, partially modeled on Italian author Giovanni Boccaccio's *Decameron*, tells the story of pilgrims on the road to the shrine of **Thomas Becket** (see 1170); it was begun in 1387.

At the **Battle of Kosovo**, in 1389, the Ottomans defeated the Serbs and Bosnians, **smashing the Serbian empire** and absorbing most of its territories. The Ottoman leader, Murad, was killed in the battle but his son **Bayezid the Thunderbolt** (1360–1403) took over. News of Murad's death prompted the **Ottoman vassals** in Europe and Anatolia to **revolt**, but Bayezid swiftly reduced most of them, bringing their territories under **direct Ottoman rule**. The Ottomans now controlled most of Anatolia and the Balkans south of the Danube. Bayezid introduced the **devshirme**—the levy of Christian children who were converted to Islam and used in the administration and **Janissary** corps.



The Timurid Empire

Established by Timur Leng, the Timurid Empire eventually reached a greater extent even than that of Genghis Khan, but it would not long survive Timur's death.

KEY

- Campaigns of Timur
- Extent of Timur's empire



A miniature from the Topkapi Museum in Istanbul, shows the Battle of Nicopolis, at which the Ottomans destroyed a crusading army.

THE START OF THE MING DYNASTY IN CHINA TRIGGERED CHANGE IN KOREA

which was considered a client state by the Ming. The **Koryo empire** had supported the new Chinese dynasty, but this did not prevent the Ming from threatening to invade. In 1388, **Yi Songgye** (1335–1408), a leading general who favored the Chinese, seized power in Korea. In 1392, as **King Taejo**, he founded the **Yi dynasty**, also known as the Choson (or Joseon), a name taken from an ancient Korean kingdom. Taejo restructured his government on the Chinese model, and instituted **wide-ranging land reforms** to redistribute estates from the hands of the oligarchy, replacing them with a new class of technocrats known as the yangban. **Neo-Confucianism** was adopted as the state religion, and a new capital was founded at **Hanseong** (Seoul). The Yi dynasty lasted until 1910.

In **Japan**, the union of the northern and southern imperial courts in 1392 brought to an end the **Yoshino period** (also known as the Period of Northern and Southern

Courts). During this period, the line of the emperor **Godaigo**—driven out of the capital, Kyoto, by the Ashikaga shogun Takauji, in 1336—had maintained a **rival court** in the mountainous Yoshino region south of Nara. Japan was wracked by **civil war** until the shogun **Ashikaga Yoshimitsu** (1358–1408) negotiated a reunification and brought Ashikaga power to its apogee.

The **Nicopolis Crusade** of 1396—intended to roll back the Ottoman advance in the Balkans—saw a Franco-Hungarian expedition led by **Sigismund of Hungary** humiliatingly crushed at the Bulgarian town of Nicopolis on the Danube. A huge army, featuring volunteers from most of the **Christian states**, proved ill-disciplined. The failure of this adventure proved that Christian Europe had to look to its defense.

Gyeongbokgung Palace

This colossal palace, built by King Taejo (Yi Songgye) in 1395, is also known as the "Palace of Shining Happiness" and the "Palace Greatly Blessed by Heaven."



1386 Jagiello of Lithuania, the last pagan ruler in Europe, is crowned king of Poland and converts to Christianity

1387 English writer Geoffrey Chaucer begins to write the Canterbury Tales

1388 Milan, under Gian Galeazzo Visconti, adds Padua to other conquests in northern Italy

1389 Wenceslas IV, king of Bohemia and Holy Roman Emperor, enacted a general peace in Germany

1392 League of Bologna: Florence, Bologna, Padua, and Ferrara join together to oppose Milan

1392 Yi (Choson) dynasty begins in Korea

1395 Timur Leng routs the Golden Horde and despoils their khanate

1396 Battle of Nicopolis: Ottomans repel the Crusader campaign

1399 Henry IV deposes Richard II in England

1399 Welsh ruler Owain Glyndwr leads a Welsh rebellion

1386 Timur Leng completes the conquest of Persia and sacks Georgia

1387 War between Timur Leng and the Golden Horde

1388 John Wycliffe's English translation of the Bible published; a later version is known as the Lollard's Bible

1389 Battle of Kosovo: Serbian empire absorbed by Ottomans

1392 End of the Yoshino period in Japan; Northern and Southern Courts are reunited

1393 Timur Leng completes the conquest of Il-Khanate

1399 Henry IV deposes Richard II in England

1399 Welsh ruler Owain Glyndwr leads a Welsh rebellion